

Community of Practice T&L

Meeting 5

10 June 2026

The meeting focused on Indigenous Knowledge as a Topic of Inquiry. The session examined how Indigenous knowledges are informing, shaping and transforming teaching, learning and curriculum design, research practices and community engagement across the Faculty. Rather than focusing solely on content inclusion, the discussion considered current initiatives and challenges to these initiatives throughout the faculty.

Unlike previous sessions, this session (and future ones) will discuss the topic of inquiry through the following questions:

1. What are we great at?
2. What do we want to be great at?
3. What should we move beyond?

The discussion in this session natural steered away from the three questions above, which is reflected in the summary notes herein. The key outcome of this session was the necessity for faculty-based community on Indigenous Knowledge which will support academics as well as relieve the cultural load from Indigenous colleagues.

In the first 15 minutes of the session, Mohammed gave the community a summary of the most recent faculty exec CoP meeting, as well as introduced to the CoP the strategy dashboard.

Below is a summary of the topics of inquiry that have been addressed already (highlighted in green), and the ones that will be addressed in the coming weeks. Meeting 6 has been updated to focus on the strategy and themes (as per the video above) as a central milestone for the CoP T&L.

Meeting #	Topic if Inquiry
1	Intros
2	What are we good at, what do we improve on, what do we let go of
3	technology
4	Student Experience
5	Indigenous Knowledge
6	Strategy Themes
7	(c)reativity
8	International
9	Interdisciplinarity
10	Competition

Below is the summary of meeting 5.

Current State

1. We are strong in Indigenous work in research, but not as strong in translating this into teaching and learning.
2. Non-Indigenous colleagues are finding it difficult to engage confidently with Indigenous Knowledge in teaching.
3. Allies in Indigenous teaching are trying to contribute, but do not feel adequately supported to contribute in an impactful and meaningful way.
4. A circulated letter that addresses many of the obstacles to celebrating Indigenous Knowledges in the classroom at UTS was delivered into the CoP.

Institutional Support

- There is a lack of investment from the university to genuinely embed Indigenous Knowledge in courses.
- There is a clear disconnect between academic aspirations and institutional support.
- Good initiatives are happening, but, they are not being communicated across Schools, such as:
 - Specialised pay rates for Indigenous guests
 - 'Aboriginal Sydney Now' elective (which has the potential to be rolled out across the faculty)
 - Some schools are working directly with Jumbunna to support and improve student experience, this should be clearly rolled out across all schools.

Risks to Consider

- There is a risk in homogenising Indigenous Knowledge across all teaching and simplifying/misrepresenting the knowledge.
 - Without careful consideration, this can create culturally unsafe environments, particularly for Indigenous colleagues and students.
 - Specialisation is important to considered delivery.
- Subjects that engage with Indigenous members and communities may seem financially expensive, however their value and impact on staff, students, pedagogy and reputation far outweigh their cost.

Future Aspirations needing Support

As a faculty, we must ensure our intent is reflected by our actions. The following is a list of initiatives that will strengthen the delivery and engagement of Indigenous Knowledge within the various disciplines in FDS:

- Greater ability to invite Indigenous community members and Elders into classes and facilitate direct engagement between students and community. Although guest lectures are a great way to convey knowledge, facilitating more intimate sessions between Indigenous community members and students will serve a very different and powerful purpose in the student education.
- Opportunities to take large cohorts of students on site to learn directly from traditional owners of land.

- Recognition that community engagement cannot always be pre-planned. Academics need flexibility to respond and engage in real time.
- Need for a clearly identified and healthy budget for engaging community members.
- Strong need for training for staff to deliver IK in a culturally safe and appropriate way, facilitating improved professional competency in this space.
- The delivery of compulsory elective/modules on Indigenous knowledge (similar to the compulsory TD elective).

Indigenous Community of Practice

- A significant portion of the above can be facilitated through a faculty based and ongoing Indigenous community of practice. The community would lead Discipline specific Indigenous Knowledge workshops, sessions to help train academics to develop competency in this space, support IGA development and ongoing implementation, and more. Members in this community would be allocated a role that is formally recognised by the university and has allocated workload for it.
 - The school of Communication used to have IGA (Indigenous Graduate Attribute) Champions, which was a great way for certain academics to support and map Indigenous Knowledge across all subjects and disciplines in the school. This was incredibly helpful in removing cultural load from Indigenous colleagues.